

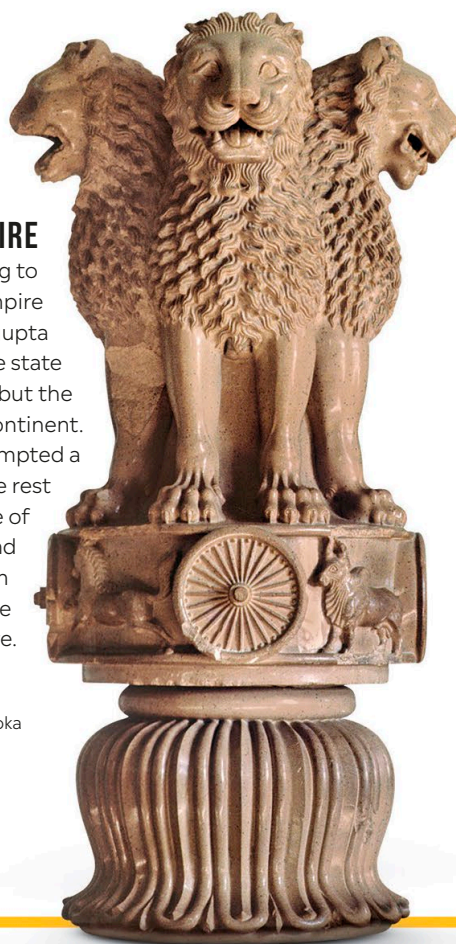
268–232 BCE

ASHOKA RULES THE MAURYA EMPIRE

Ashoka began his reign intending to continue the expansion of the empire begun by his grandfather Chandragupta Maurya. Once he had conquered the state of Kalinga in 261 BCE, he ruled over all but the extreme south of the Indian subcontinent.

The bloody Kalinga campaign prompted a change of heart, and he devoted the rest of his reign to spreading the doctrine of Buddhism, declaring his moral and social “edicts” by having them inscribed on pillars topped with stone animal capitals around the empire.

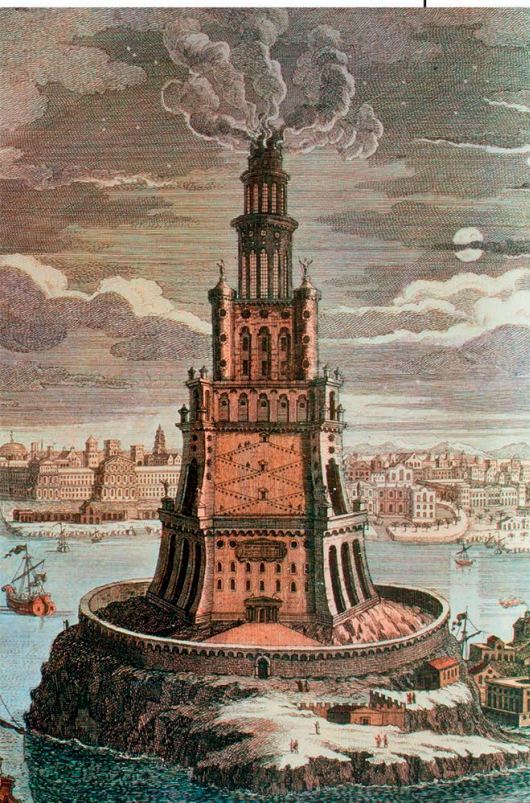
▷ The Lion Capital of Ashoka



280 BCE **The Colossus of Rhodes**, a statue at the entrance to the city's harbour, is completed

c. 260 BCE **Ashoka converts to Buddhism** and commissions the building of the Great Stupa at Sanchi

300 BCE



285 BCE

THE LIGHTHOUSE AT ALEXANDRIA IS BUILT

Construction of a monumental lighthouse on the small island of Pharos off the coast of Egypt was completed during the reign of Ptolemy II Philadelphus. After 12 years of building work, it stood some 100 m (330 ft) high, the tallest building in the world at that time. The structure, often known as the Pharos of Alexandria, lasted until damaged by earthquakes in the 10th century CE.

◁ Pharos of Alexandria



264–241 BCE

THE FIRST PUNIC WAR

The 3rd century BCE saw three long wars between the Romans and the Carthaginians. The two powers fought for supremacy over the western Mediterranean, but the Romans also took the war into Carthaginian territory in North Africa, notably at the massive naval battle of Ecnomus. After the First Punic War, which lasted 23 years, the Romans defeated the Carthaginians and took control of Sicily.